

Architectural Diffusion: Parthenon and U.S. Supreme Court – ARCH 150 Assignment 2



Parthenon, Athens, Greece. Classical Greek Civilization, 447–432 BCE. View of the temple on the Acropolis showing the canonical Doric colonnade and triangular pediment.



Close-up of marble columns and lintel construction. Greek masons used post-and-lintel stone blocks, precisely cut and proportioned, reflecting early codified principles of classical architecture.



U.S. Supreme Court, Washington, D.C., United States, 1935. Modern reinterpretation of the Classical Greek temple, adapted for civic and judicial authority in the U.S. capital.



Detail of façade colonnade. Concrete and stone cladding replicate the Doric order. The visual borrowing underscores the continued symbolic power of Greek architectural ideals.

The diffusion process illustrated is the re-use of form in a different material. The Parthenon, constructed in marble using post-and-lintel methods, provided the archetype of classical temple form. Centuries later, the U.S. Supreme Court adapted this model using modern materials such as concrete and steel, clad in stone. By emulating the Parthenon's colonnaded façade and pediment, American architects symbolically connected civic law to ideals of order, democracy, and permanence. This demonstrates how ancient Greek architectural language was preserved and reinterpreted to suit new cultural and political contexts.

Sources (Chicago Style):

“The Parthenon in Athens.” Photograph. Wikimedia Commons. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:The_Parthenon_in_Athens.jpg

“United States Supreme Court Building – Main Entrance.” Photograph. Wikimedia Commons.
https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:US_Supreme_Court_building-Main_entrance.jpg

Photo by Polina Tankilevitch. “Columns in Corner of Parthenon.” Pexels. <https://www.pexels.com/photo/columns-in-corner-of-parthenon-15186544/>

Photo by Nitin Dhumal. “Supreme Court of the USA.” Pexels. <https://www.pexels.com/photo/supreme-court-of-the-usa-17843099/>